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Gov. Newsom signs bills aiming to bolster mental health care, ease homelessness

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On the eve of the end of the state's pandemic-spurred ban on evictions, Gov. Gavin Newsom on Wednesday, Sept. 29, signed a multi-billion-dollar package of bills aimed at what officials called a "historic" rebuilding of mental health services and housing in a larger push to ease the homeless crisis.

The legislation, which included four bills authored by a trio of Southern California state assemblymembers, will invest billions in building up an infrastructure of more than 44,000 new housing units and treatment beds for people exiting homelessness, officials said, including $5.8 billion to add more than 35,000 new housing units through the state's Project Homekey program.

In particular, $3 billion will be allotted to house people with acute behavioral and physical health needs while creating 22,000 new beds and treatment slots.

Newsom, flanked by L.A. Mayor Eric Garcetti, Los Angeles County Supervisor Hilda Solis, and state lawmakers including Assembly members Luz Rivas, D-Arleta, and Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, said the bills, part of a larger $22 billion in investment, forged a new "paradigm" in rebuilding a statewide system of care dismantled in the late 1960s.

"Let's be honest," Newsom said, speaking at the Alvarado Care Home in Los Angeles, the kind of care facility that would be bolstered by the new funding. "This county, this state. We need to do more and we need to better. We have a unique responsibility because nothing like the homeless crisis exists anywhere else in the United State like it exists and persists here in the state of California."

Newsom pointed to legislation, advanced by Rivas and Gabriel, that centers around the newly formed California Interagency Council on Homelessness, which would sign off on local governments' plans to deal with homelessness.

The agency will receive, review and approve plans as part of the state's $2 billion local homelessness assistance package through the Homeless Housing, Assistance and Prevention Program, according to the governor's office.

Under the new law, local governments "must commit to quantifiable goals across six standardized metrics and make progress towards meeting or exceeding them in order to receive their full share of HHAP funding."

Newsom said the legislation was an effort to infuse a level of accountability into the effort to deal with the crisis.

"No plan. No money," he said, adding that the state would provide 18% bonuses to local governments that "actually produce real results." "We're coming in with not just sticks but with real carrots, real incentives."

Gabriel's AB 977 creates a system of reporting requirements. Data collected would be made available to the Legislature and the public, which Gabriel said would allow for stronger oversight of state and local homelessness programs.

Rivas said the state was in dire need of a new approach to homelessness.

"Accountability is also desperately needed," she said.

The governor also signed Rivas' AB 27, which creates a standardized process to identify California's homeless students and refer them to services.

"In California there are enough homeless children to fill Dodger Stadium five times," said Rivas, reflecting on her own elementary school in the San Fernando Valley. "Let that sink in. We have to end that."

Dr. Mark Ghaly, secretary of California Health and Human Services, said the sweeping package of bills aimed to build up a statewide infrastructure of services, as well as such brick-and-mortar homes as Alvarado Care Home. The package builds on efforts, highlighted during the pandemic, that converted motels and hotels into housing, Newsom said.

For years, advocates for people suffering from mental illness have pointed to the need for more housing and treatment options.

Few disagree that is the issue of the time, but many disagree on how to approach it. The policy pendulum swings from arguments that emphasize a public safety approach to others that emphasize housing and outreach.

In L.A. County, more than six in every 10 people unhoused are experiencing some form of mental illness. And often, shelters are ill-equipped to serve their needs.

Newsom's visit comes as the state's pandemic-era eviction moratorium is set to sunset on Thursday, a moment many fear will deeply worsen the homeless issue.

Officials said this week that in L.A. County more than 744,000 households are behind on rent.

"Of course we're concerned about it," Newsom said, saying that what doesn't end are protections for low-income renters and landlords that extend beyond the moratorium into March of next year.

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